but made no provisions whatever about the boundary between Tibet and Ladakh.'

Almost half a century later, the British Minister to China, Sir Claude MacDonald, again tried to address the boundary issue, suggesting the demarcation of the frontier between Sinkiang and Tibet with Ladakh. Once again China refused to accept the proposal. Subsequently, the Chinese would point to the MacDonald proposal as proof that none of the earlier arguments held any water as the proposal itself proved that the boundary had not been delimited. However, on closer scrutiny, the MacDonald proposal was a major deviation from the earlier established boundary. The new proposal, in fact, drew a line from the Karakoram Pass towards the east —very different from any Indian or British map of that time. Ironically, the MacDonald line would have placed more than half of the Aksai Chin in Chinese territory.

The Chinese refusing to get pinned down was not specific to just the western section of the boundary. Post-independence, with Pakistan coming into play, the Sino-Indian boundary became even more complicated.

INDO-TIBET BOUNDARY (CENTRAL SECTOR)

In the central sector, the area from Spiti to the junction of India, Nepal and Tibet is a distance of 640 kilometres. The main points of dispute between China and India have been in Spiti, Barahoti, and the Nilang region next to the Shipki Pass. These disputes have festered for decades and have never been settled. India's stated stand is that the Sino-Indian Trade Agreement of 1954 defines the boundary line along the axis of six passes in the region. The Chinese claim that the trade agreement had nothing to do with defining the frontier. The Indians also claim Chuva and Chuje, as per the 1684 and 1842 treaties, belong to India. Peking has, in reference to the Western Sector, already rejected these treaties. Wu-Je, yet another area, was first contested between the two countries in 1954. India claims the boundary here was confirmed by the correspondence between 1889 and 1890, and then again in 1914. China says that the boundary was never formally agreed upon.

Known as Kedarkhand or Uttarakhand in ancient Indian literature, the Garhwal and Kumaon regions were a combined political entity. Lying to the east of the Sutlej River catchment, the region extended up to the Sharda or Kali Ganga River that traditionally separated it from Nepal in the east.